interview, responding to Kennedy by repeating lines from his speech and ridiculing his professed concern about the freedom and well-being of Cubans. Castro declared himself open to dialogue but stressed: “Anyone who tries to come and inspect Cuba must know that he will have to come equipped for war. That is our final answer to illusions and proposals for carrying out inspections on our territory.” He did not confirm or deny the presence of nuclear weapons on Cuban soil but asserted that all weapons were defensive.[5]

Castro’s firm stand helped to calm his supporters. The panic that had swept the corridors of power in Havana after Kennedy’s address gave way to relative calm in the next few days. But with heightened activity at the UN on October 24–25, resulting in the Stevenson-Zorin interchange, a new wave of panic hit Havana. Castro’s agents in New York, working under cover of the state news agency Prensa Latina, had intercepted an American telegram suggesting that Kennedy was preparing an ultimatum to the acting UN secretary general, U Thant, demanding the removal of offensive weapons from Cuba. Castro was worried. If Kennedy delivered such an ultimatum, it could mean the diplomatic preparations for an invasion. Castro was convinced of the reliability of his intelligence by the increasing American overflights of the island.[6]

On Friday, October 26, diplomats accredited to the Cuban government in Havana began to pick up signs of tension. “The Cubans have further expanded their battle preparedness and are now at maximum readiness,” reported the Czechoslovak ambassador in Havana, Vladimir Pavliček. The Yugoslav ambassador, Boško Vidaković, who visited the Cuban president, Osvaldo Dorticós, that afternoon, found him in a state of utmost concern. The Brazilian ambassador in Cuba, Bastian Pinto, reported to his capital on the basis of his conversation with Vidaković that “Dorticós, extremely perturbed, told him that American planes are making low-level flights over Cuba and, according to information obtained in recent hours, the American attack is imminent; it would even be a ‘miracle’ if the attack does not come this evening, repeat: this evening.”[7]

While Dorticós met with friendly ambassadors, hoping to mobilize the international community against the invasion that he expected at any moment, Castro rallied his troops and readied his defenses. He ordered his